

The highlights here are for people who want to prepare for what is coming in the next couple of months and years. In these areas I think OpenSUSE is pretty much ahead on the curve. We also have support for KDE and GNOME, so for users who want a choice between KDE and GNOME, OpenSUSE is the perfect option. OpenSUSE 12.3 is the best you can currently get in terms of booting the dual boot software in the hardware.

Q Was it a deliberate move to choose the Linux 3.7 kernel in OpenSUSE 12.3?

That's the question of stabilisation. There is a certain point in time when we freeze the kernel version for release, and then we port fixes and features of Linux kernel 3.8. But the version number is 3.7++. Again, if you want to have driver support for hardware, almost everything in Kernel 3.8 is on 3.7. But in terms of the dependencies of the built, we freeze the kernel at a point in time and then we just add patches from the newer version. So, my answer is: yes, it's called Linux 3.7, but if you look under the cover, you will find that it is almost Linux 3.8.

The new avatar of SUSE

Q How has SUSE changed after being acquired by the Attachmate Group—in terms of the policies related with the software?

There have not been many changes in SUSE engineering. All our engineering processes have worked very well before as well, and so we continue to keep them. I think what has really changed is the unleashing of the SUSE brand. Now you see more green everywhere as well as the new branding. We have been able to be more innovative again. Under Novell, we were more limited as far as innovation was concerned. For example, on the enterprise products, we were the first ones to release an enterprise grade 3.0 kernel in the SUSE 11 service pack 2. We released the Kernel 3.0 with our enterprise product. And we just did not release it, but we first made it compatible to the product certifications. So, users could upgrade from service pack 1 to service pack 2. Red Hat, which is comparatively much bigger and more popular, still doesn't have the 3.0 kernel out. I think these are the areas in which we are again able to be more innovative.

SUSE and the open source community

Q What role has SUSE played in adding value to the growth of Linux and open source?

SUSE just had its 20th anniversary last year. I think we are one of the grandfathers of Linux. We were one of the first to create a distribution to make Linux consumable. We have the first enterprise product with the Linux enterprise server. So in terms of productising Linux, we have definitely been a key player. SUSE has also been good in terms of hardware

support, whether it was for the graphic cards where you had to use SUSE to do your work or the secure boot machines. The members of my staff each have between 10-20 years of Linux experience and they are all very active in the upstream community. So look at any popular open source project like GNOME, KDE or the Linux Kernel, and you will find SUSE people working there. All the engineers at SUSE have two roles. One side of them is very business oriented, while the other side is very community oriented. So, we never forget that the success of Linux is not because of SUSE or Red Hat, it's because of the community. We contribute heavily to the community and we will, forever, continue to do that.

Q What percentage of SUSE employees interact with the community on a regular basis?

Some of the people in SUSE Labs devote most of their time to community initiatives. They help in building the Linux kernel, something that we at SUSE also need, but they all do upstream work in their productisation phase. While there are other people in the company, like in QA, who spend comparatively less time upstream. But they watch mailing lists and submit back reports. It's hard to give a general answer but like I mentioned earlier, every SUSE employee has two sides—business and community. The mix depends on the role they perform. Interaction with the community is almost mandatory for all SUSE employees. It's actually a criterion for hiring. So our first question to an engineer is, "What have you done in terms of open source? Have you contributed to any community; do you know about open source developments?" And so on. These are the key questions in our hiring process.

Q How much of the contributions to the OpenSUSE project come from India?

The Indian community has traditionally been very active around GNOME and Evolution. In the bigger picture, many majors like Intel and IBM have a couple of luminaries in India, and a handful of them can be seen at the Linux Kernel summit. Though the number of contributors from India is in no way proportional to the country's population, there are some really good contributions coming from the country. But you see more contributions coming from North America and Europe. I think it is still the early stages for open source in India and it is not so compatible with the culture. The open source communities can be really harsh. In the Indian or the Chinese culture, if you get flamed publicly on a mailing list because your patch wasn't perfect, it gets intimidating to a lot of people. While, in the western culture, being open and critical is not seen as a personal insult. Instead, it is seen as a method of making things better. The tone on these open source communities can be very rough, which is hindering the contributors from both India and China. 